Cypress Street

Have you noticed any changes in the area in which you live? What are these changes? Let us read about the changes that the poet noticed on a street called Cypress Street.

I took a stroll down Cypress Street
The hot sidewalk beneath my feet.

The one thing that stood out the most …
Where trees once stood there were lamppost.

I'd never seen so much concrete
No cypress left on Cypress Street.

According to my Great Aunt Gem
There used to be a lot of them.

They cut them down. They took their wood
A treeless street is plum no good!

Just like a treeless neighbourhood

So tell the Mayor next time they meet …
To change the name to Lamppost Street!

Todd-Michael St Pierre

Todd-Michael St Pierre writes poems, songs and plays for children. He is a storyteller at schools throughout the southern United States. Among his published works are *Somewhere: As Told by the Parrot* and *The Louisiana State Bird Beauty Pageant.* St Pierre lives in St Francisville, Louisiana, with his Siamese twin cats. This poem is from *Put the People in a Zoo and Set the Animals Free.*

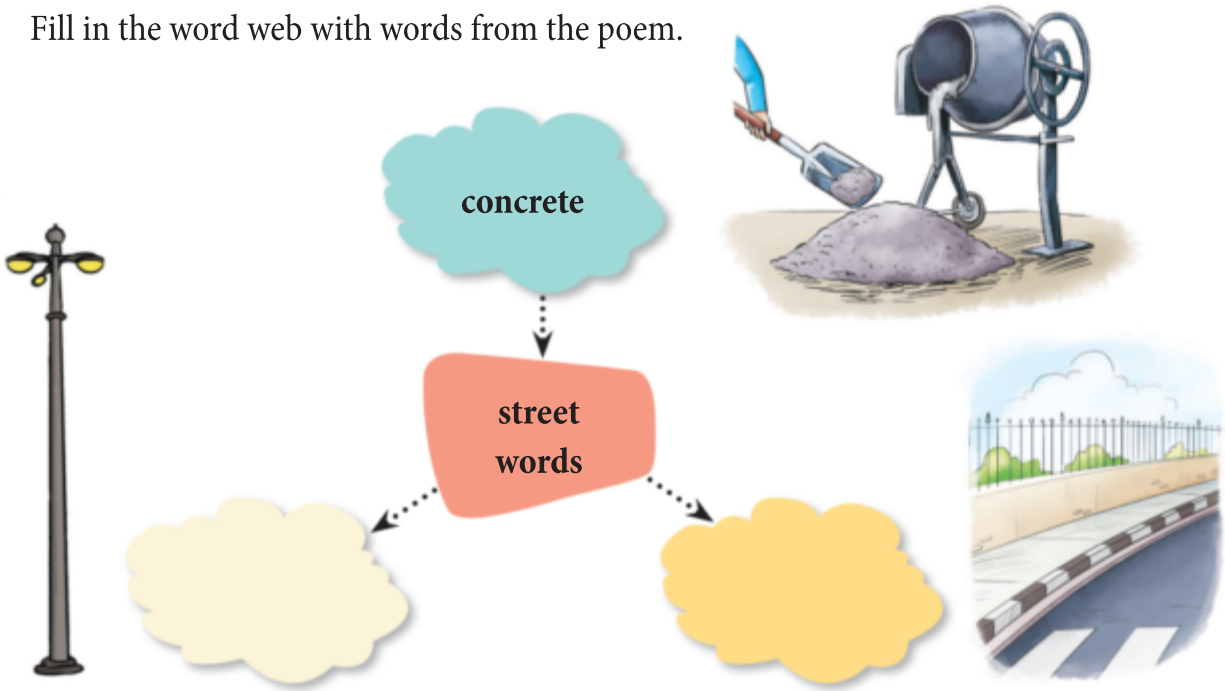
stroll: a relaxed walk sidewalk: footpath; a path at the side of the road for people to walk on
stood out: was easy to notice concrete: a building material made from broken stones, cement, water and sand
plum no good: not good; useless Mayor: the head of a town

In this section, we will:
- analyse details of the poem.
(C-2.1, 2.2)

Make connections

Answer the following questions based on the poem.

1. Fill in the word web with words from the poem.



2. Tick the right answer.
   a. In the poem, the poet walked down the street because
      i. he had something important to do. ○
      ii. he wanted to check how hot the concrete was. ○
      iii. he wanted to enjoy a walk. ○
   b. '*A treeless street is plum no good!*' This means
      i. plum trees are not good to plant on streets. ○
      ii. streets must have trees. ○
      iii. treeless streets are good to walk on. ○
3. Read these lines and answer the questions that follow.
   a. *According to my Great Aunt Gem*
      There used to be a lot of them.
      i. What does the word 'them' refer to?
      ii. In these lines, find the antonym of 'not many' or 'just a few'.
      iii. What change has Great Aunt Gem noticed?

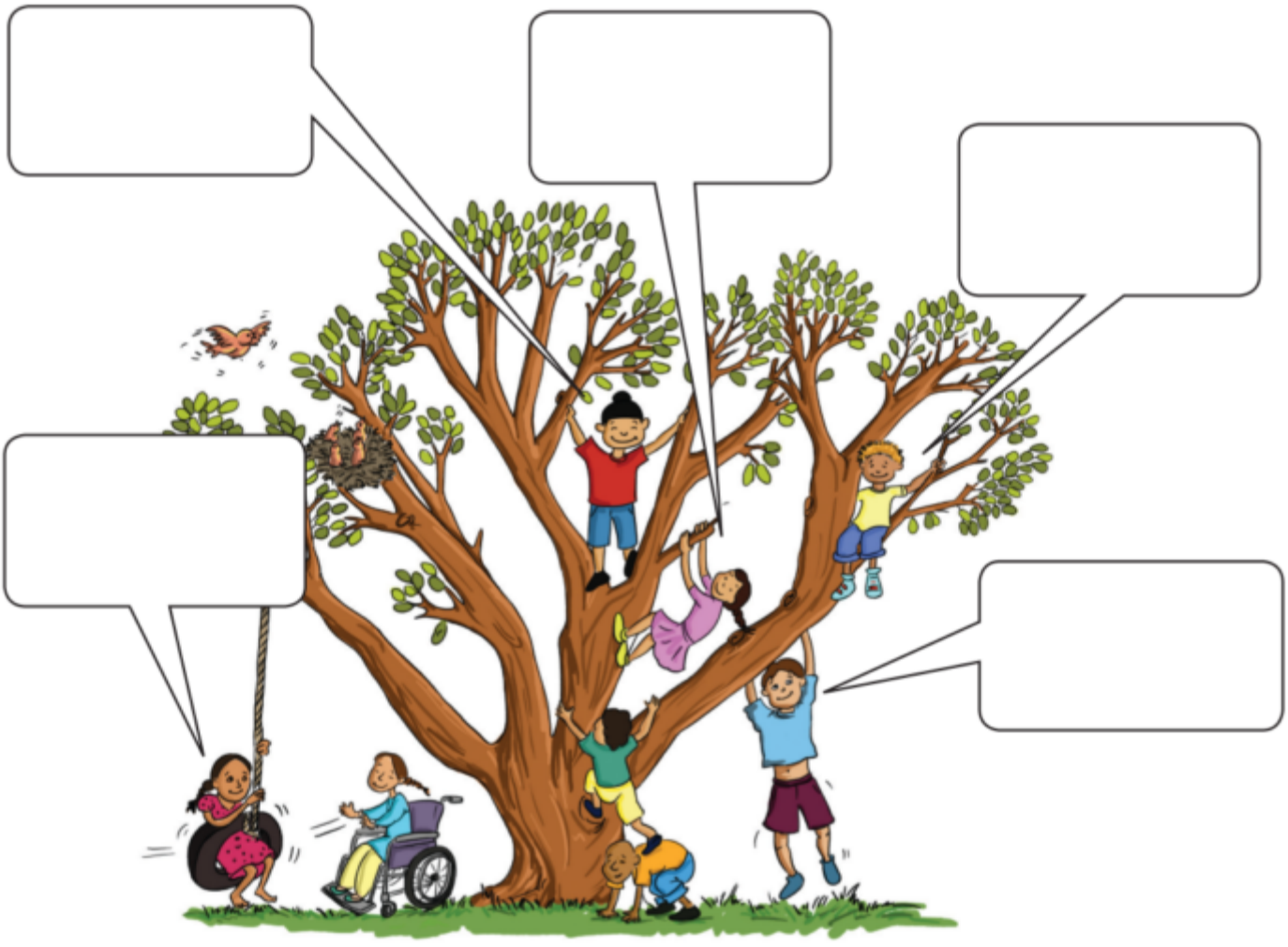
b. *They cut them down. They took their wood*
A treeless street is plum no good!

i. The poet tells us that 'they' cut down the trees. Who do you think cut down the trees?

ii. Why were the trees cut down?

iii. According to the poet, what else is no good without trees?

4. Would it make the poet happy to have the name of the street changed to 'Lamppost Street'? Give a reason for your answer.
5. Why do you think the poet has written this poem?
6. What do you think the Mayor should discuss at the next meeting?
7. The poet says a neighbourhood without trees is no good. Why is it important to have trees in a neighbourhood? Write your reasons in the speech bubbles.



In this section, we will:
- learn about rhythm and rhyme.
- use rhyming words to write a couplet.
(C-2.1, 2.2, 3.3)

Appreciation

Rhyme and rhythm

1. **List the rhyming word pairs in the poem.**
2. **Poems have rhythm and rhyme. Let us play some games to get a feel of rhythm and rhyme.**

   We will first begin with rhythm. Clap your hands and snap your fingers in this pattern:

   clap clap snap snap

   Do it till the whole class is in rhythm.

   Now instead of the second snap, say the rhyming pairs from the poem.

   clap clap snap street

   clap clap snap feet

   clap clap snap most

   clap clap snap lamppost … and so on

   If you get this right, you can go to the next step.

   Change the clap rhythm and give rhyming words, taken from the cues that your teacher gives you. You can do this in teams. See how long you can go without breaking the rhythm.

   This is how you could start:

   clap snap clap clap

   clap snap clap tell (teacher)

   clap snap clap well (student 1)

   clap snap clap shell (student 2)

   clap snap clap fell (student 3)

   clap snap clap sell (student 4)
3. **Couplets are two lines of verse with a fun and simple rhyming pattern. They can be individual poems or part of a bigger poem. Each line often has the same number of syllables and their endings must rhyme with each other. Read the following couplets.**

   a. I travel to many different far-off lands
      With my imagination and a book in my hands.

   b. Trees are budding and animal babies hatch,
      Joyfully I water my flower patch.

   Now use some rhyming pairs to write couplets of your own.